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ART & CULTURE

Indian Art and Culture — Part 3

Class 11

Author: Prof. M. Iyengar

Published by NCERT Library for IAS

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Chapter 1

Architecture Through the Ages

Indian architecture spans millennia, from the Indus Valley cities to modern structures. Buddhist stupas at Sanchi, rock-cut caves at Ajanta and Ellora, and Hindu temples such as Kailasa and Brihadeshvara reflect diverse traditions. Indo-Islamic architecture introduced domes, arches and minarets, reaching its zenith in Mughal monuments like the Taj Mahal. Colonial architecture blended European and Indian elements. Each tradition contributes to India's rich architectural heritage and continuity of craft.

Chapter 2

Classical Dances of India

India recognizes eight classical dance forms: Bharatanatyam, Kathak, Odissi, Manipuri, Kuchipudi, Mohiniyattam, Sattriya and Kathakali. Each draws from the Natya Shastra, the ancient treatise on performing arts, and combines nritta (pure dance), nritya (expressive dance) and natya (drama). Dance communicates stories from mythology, conveys spiritual themes and preserves regional traditions. The guru-shishya parampara ensures the transmission of these art forms across generations.

Chapter 3

Music and Musical Traditions

Indian music is divided into the Hindustani classical tradition of the north and the Carnatic tradition of the south. Both are built on raga (melodic framework) and tala (rhythmic cycle). The Sama Veda is the earliest source of Indian musical thought. Instruments such as the sitar, veena, tabla and mridangam accompany vocal and instrumental performances. Music in India is deeply intertwined with devotion, season, time of day and emotion, reflecting a sophisticated aesthetic philosophy.